was in 1858, in the first volume of his work, where he wrote on the origin of caste, an inquiry intended to show that it did not exist in the Vedic age. In this volume, he also wrote extensively on the origin and history of the people of India while describing the geographical conceptions of the Puranas and equated 'Bharatavarsa' with India. This was probably one of the earliest arguments on Bharat by a British Indologist.

About 35 years later, German Orientalist Gustav Oppert went a step further in 1893 and forcefully argued that 'Bharatavarsa' was the "only relevant national designation for India". He argued that the name Bharat alone is capable of bridging the divide between what he classified as 'Aryan' and 'Dravidian'.

Incidentally, 'Bharat' was considered to be an idea that connects every 'Bharatiya' and gives him or her an identity that is unique and has deep roots in tradition and cultural moorings. The argument that India's foundational principles will change if its name is changed to Bharat is as irrational an argument as it is absurd. The name Bharat is enshrined in the Constitution clearly and all the attributes of India apply to Bharat also.

Perhaps no one could have argued for Bharat more vehemently than veteran Congress leader Kamalapati Tripathi who declared that, "I am enamoured of the historic name of 'Bharat'... Even after thousands of years, our country is still known as 'Bharat'. Since Vedic times, this name has been appearing in our literature. Our Puranas have all through eulogised the name of Bharat."

The 'Bharat' debate that began on September 18, 1949, in the Constituent Assembly has been revived after 74 years. It would be in the best interests of the country to debate the issue further. Considering the arguments put forward by the veterans of the Congress party during the Constituent Assembly debates, they seem to have a much greater stake in the name Bharat being adopted unanimously.

The issue is not who gets the credit but how soon and how unanimously we can adopt the name Bharat as envisaged by the framers of the Constitution. ■

WHILE THE GOVERNMENT IS NOT OFFERING ANY REASONING FOR THE NAME CHANGE, THE OPPOSITION SEEMS TO HAVE BEEN CAUGHT ON THE WRONG FOOT

– Seshadri Chari is a former editor of Organiser



By **RAVINDER KAUR**

BRAND NEW INDIA

FROM INCREDIBLE INDIA IN 2002 TO DIGITAL INDIA NOW, BRAND INDIA EMERGED AS AN INFLUENTIAL LOCUS OF INTERACTION WITH THE WORLD AND THE NATION

On September 5, 2023, #Bharat was the most tweeted and the longest-trending topic on Indian social media. The day began with intense speculation that the Modi government was about to cancel one of the two constitutional names of the country, India, to privilege the other, Bharat. But what was hailed as a gesture of decolonisation, a return to authentic naming traditions, soon took an unexpected turn: a speculative suggestion surfaced that Pakistan may claim the name 'India' if India chooses to abandon it.

This mere whiff of a rumour was enough to spark mirthful internet memes laced with disbelief in equal measure. Why would India's neighbour and foe court an identity it had once